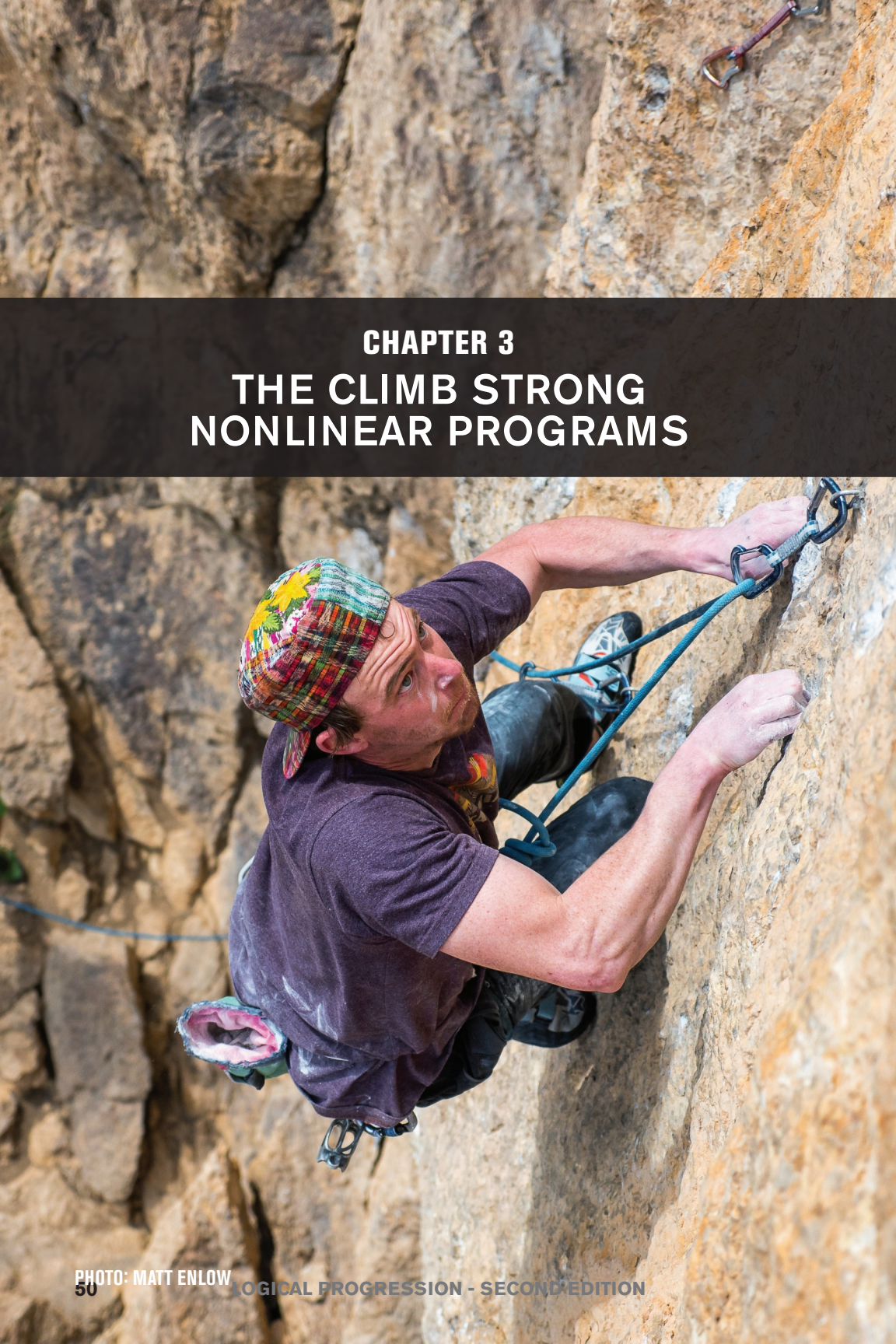


A man is climbing a rock face. He is wearing a purple t-shirt, black pants, and a colorful, patterned cap. He is using a blue rope and a metal carabiner to secure himself. The rock face is light-colored and textured. The background is a dark, solid color.

CHAPTER 3

THE CLIMB STRONG NONLINEAR PROGRAMS

You can use a linear plan in designing your calendar, or you can use a nonlinear plan. I feel that a nonlinear development of abilities in climbing is more effective for most climbers. Why? Because our physical preparation is not the whole game in training for climbing...it is something that occurs in the background and must be coaxed along “behind the scenes” while we go out and try to develop skills and tactics and techniques on the rock.

In these programs, we simply cycle between three or four workout structures, each focusing on a different training stimulus. The beauty of such a plan is it fits well within a normal person’s life structure and allows for almost unlimited variability. Performance phases are governed simply by ramping up the volume of training during certain times of year, and backing off during others, all the while allowing you to maintain the same simple cycle of training. I want your training to support your performance in the sport. What most of us need from training is a basic structure of athleticism and mobility that allows us to practice our climbing skills at the highest level. Training simply develops performance potential - realizing that potential is another matter. This is why you must not let training overrun your practice. If you constantly look to drive your improvement at the crag, and keep training on a supporting role, you will see improvements year-after-year.

I have put together three training programs that use the nonlinear programming model. As I wrote earlier, the Level I program is the best choice for those new to training or who have been climbing only a few years. The Level II program alternates between two

different plan structures every four weeks. The Level III program alternates between three.

WHAT IF I GET OUT OF SEQUENCE?

One of the most common concerns climbers have about nonlinear cycles is messing up the order of the training. Although we see the sequences presented in the programs in this book as ideal, it's important to understand that each session positively affects the others, and the sequencing is not as important as making sure you hit each of the session types regularly.

Getting off sequence can happen for many reasons, the most common of which seems to be coordinating training facilities or partners. If you have a strength session planned for Saturday and your spouse wants to boulder, flipping the two sessions is fine (PRO TIP: Do what your spouse wants). It is best to avoid too much alteration of the schedule, though. It seems like when we start altering the plan we trend toward doing more of our favorite sessions and not having time for the sessions we don't like.

LEVEL I - 3 SESSIONS, 1 CYCLE

The Level I Nonlinear Program is a beautifully simple training cycle, where you simply switch between three different workouts. The normal recommendation is to do one of each session each week, but during peak training phases you might go as high as five sessions. You might drop as low as two sessions during recovery phases. I recommend shorter, more frequent training sessions, because that gives you the most opportunity for high-quality training. No matter what the frequency of sessions, you simply keep going through the sequence of strength - power - endurance.

The program consists of three session formats: Strength, Power, and Endurance. These can be almost any style of session, but for the most part you'll pull from the "specific" sessions within each category below. A normal week might look like this:

MON.	TUE.	WED.	THURS.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Strength		Power		Endurance		

The beauty of the nonlinear programs, however, is that they can be adjusted to almost any schedule, with little penalty for the changes. Over time, you'll come to know how many days you need between given sessions. A two week period might look like this:

MON.	TUE.	WED.	THURS.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Strength		Power	Endurance		Strength	
Power		Endurance		Strength		Power

...or even like this:

MON.	TUE.	WED.	THURS.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Strength	Power		Endurance	Strength		Power
		Endurance	Strength		Power	Endurance

When putting your program together, I recommend keeping things as flexible as possible for as long as possible. Start restricting your program only when a more relaxed program ceases to yield improvements.

This program can be *integrated* with your climbing or *uncoupled* from it. Both methods have worked well in the field. An integrated method would be one in which your outside climbing days were part of the training plan. On such a plan you might train strength in the gym, followed by an outdoor bouldering (power) session, followed by an outdoor endurance session.

An uncoupled plan is easier to manage for most. On this style of plan, you’d keep the normal three session training format, then simply climb when at the crag. I recommend some sort of structure to your climbing days, but I’ll cover that in detail later. By training on a nonlinear cycle and following some simple guidelines at the crag, you can have a very “normal” program that cycles naturally throughout the year. A one month program set up in this way might look like this:

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THUR.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Strength	Power		Endurance		Climb Redpoint	Climb Volume
Week 2		Strength		Power		Climb Redpoint	
Week 3	Endurance	Strength		Power	Endurance		Climb Redpoint
Week 4	Strength	Power		Endurance		Climb Redpoint	Climb Volume

Specifics on the Strength, Power and Endurance sessions are covered in the **Methods of Training** section.

LEVEL II - 3 SESSIONS, 2 CYCLES

When the Level I program ceases to provide results, you can take your training one step further by adopting and *alternating cycle*. In the Level II plan, we follow the same 3-session structure, and cycle them the same as we do in Level I. The difference is that every four weeks we switch the primary focus of the cycle. Where Level I is adjusted by simply manipulating volume or intensity, the Level II plan lets you focus a little more on a given energy system each month in order to maximally develop specific qualities. This is the first step in block planning, and is sometimes the only step one needs to take.

This type of plan is especially useful for climbers who like to perform across multiple disciplines. For four weeks, your three workout cycle will focus on developing more power and strength, and the second four weeks leans toward more power-endurance and endurance. The workout structure is as follows:

	PHASE 1	PHASE 2
Session 1	Power	Endurance
Session 2	Endurance	Power
Session 3	Strength	Power Endurance

Although there is significant overlap in the two phases, Phase 1 leans toward getting you stronger, and Phase 2 tends to focus more on endurance. When planning performance phases around these cycles, you can expect your highest performances during the last week of a phase or the beginning of the next one. This means that if you are looking for a bouldering peak, it might come the first week of Phase 2, and a redpoint peak might come in the first week of Phase 1. It is helpful to plan your seasons with this in mind.

Just like the Level I program, you can integrate this with your climbing training or you can progress the two separately.

LEVEL III - 4 SESSIONS, 3 CYCLES

The most advanced nonlinear program I ever recommend is Level III. This program is designed for elite-level trainees and is the most prescriptive one in this text. This program is designed to elicit adaptations over longer cycles, but will still provide several periods of high performance each year. The plan that follows is designed specifically for gaining fitness for hard redpointing, and would have to be modified in order to see performance gains in bouldering.

This plan starts to bridge the gap between nonlinear programming and block periodization. In this plan, you switch between three different phases of training, each of them 4 weeks in length. These can loosely be described as *strength*, *power*, and *endurance*. Just like the Level I and Level II plans, you alternate between several different sessions each phase, but in Level III, you cycle between four sessions rather than three.

The structure looks like this:

	PHASE 1 (STRENGTH)	PHASE 2 (EXPLOSIVENESS)	PHASE 3 (ENDURANCE)
Session 1	Power	Power	Endurance
Session 2	Strength	Endurance	Power
Session 3	Endurance	Power	Endurance
Session 4	Strength	Strength	Power Endurance

For most climbers, the four sessions will not fit within a week. This is an important consideration, so you’ve got to be willing to let go of the mentality that your training must constantly line-up

with the calendar. Most climbers have fixed days each week that they can train. There is no reason to always do a specific session on specific days. Allowing a bit of variability is OK, and might be a game changer.

A normal month might look like this:

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THUR.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1		Power		Strength		Endurance	
Week 2	Strength	Power		Strength	Endurance		Strength
Week 3		Power		Strength	Endurance		
Week 4	Strength		Power			Strength	

It is important to remember at this point that the training is something that happens in the background of your continued development as a rock climber. Although our programming forces a focus first on strength, then on power and finally on energy system work, your first priority is always quality of movement and improvement of technical skills.

In the Level III plan, your highest performance capability will again be at the end of a given cycle or the first week of the next. After Phase 1, your finger strength will be highest, after Phase 2, your explosiveness and short power endurance will be primed, and after Phase 3, you'll have the highest pure endurance. You should adjust your redpointing schedule accordingly.